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Packing List vs Bill of Lading: Differences, Examples & Templates

A packing list explains what is packed inside the shipment. A bill of lading (BOL) focuses on transporting the freight. Many freight shipments use both documents.

Packing list vs bill of lading at a glance

Question	Bill of Lading	Packing List
Main purpo	Transporta	Packageand

	s e	t i o n / s h i p m e n t r e c o r d	c o n t e n t s r e c o r d
	C a r r i e r i n f o r m a t i o n	C e n t r a l t o t h e d o c u m e	M a y b e r e f e r e n c e d

		nt	
	Shipper/consignee	Common	Common
	Freight class/hand	Common for freight B	Not usually the foc

	linguunits	OLs	us
	Carton/palletcontents	Canbesummarized	Usuallymoredetailed
	Weigh	Comm	Comm

	ts	on	on
	Dimensions	Maybeincluded	Oftenusefulforpackagedetail
	Receivi	Helpsid	Helpsve

n g r e c o n c i l i a t i o n	e n t i f y s h i p m e n t	r i f y p a c k a g e s a n d c o n t e n t s

Example: 3 pallets with 48 cartons

The BOL may identify three pallets, total weight, freight description, carrier, shipper, consignee and handling instructions. The packing list can break those three pallets down into 48 cartons and show which SKUs and quantities are packed in each group.

Why shipments use both

The carrier needs transportation information, while the receiving team may need detailed carton-level information to verify what arrived. The documents overlap enough that shipment numbers, parties, package counts and weights should be generated from the same source data whenever possible.

Which document do you need?

If the carrier or freight forwarder asks for a BOL, use the required bill of lading format. If the receiver needs carton, SKU or package-level detail, prepare a packing list. For many commercial freight shipments, the practical answer is **both**: the BOL travels with transportation details while the packing list helps the receiver reconcile the contents.

Free Bill of Lading Template →Free Packing List Template →BOL Generator →Packing List Generator →

Common mistakes

- Using a packing list as the carrier's required BOL.
- Changing pallet or carton counts without updating both documents.
- Using different consignee or delivery information on related paperwork.
- Leaving freight descriptions too vague for the carrier or receiver.

Reminder: A carrier, broker, customer or contract can require a specific BOL format or additional fields. Use the format required for the shipment.

Frequently asked questions

Is a packing list a bill of lading?
Can I attach a packing list to a BOL?
Should the package count match?
Which document does the carrier use?

Free BOL tools

BOL GeneratorPacking List TemplatePacking List Generator

RELATED COMPARISONS

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